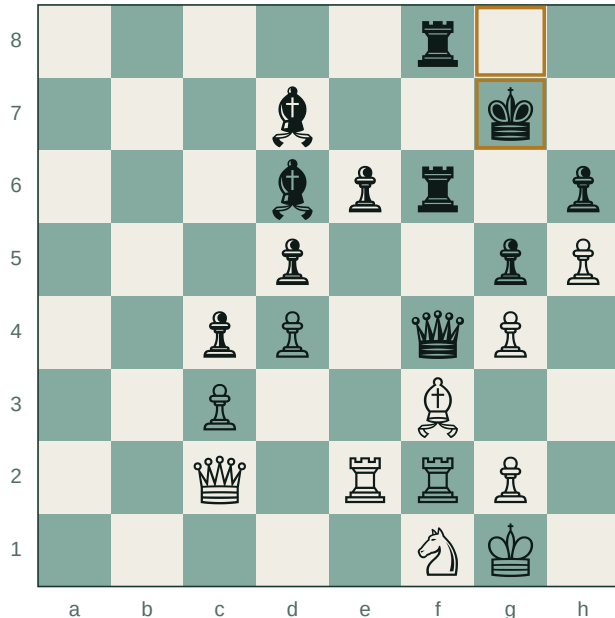


Trapping a piece: White, move 40

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 39...Kg7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

40. g3 Qxf3 41. Rxf3 Rxf3 42. Qg6+ Kh8 43. Qxh6+

40.g3 The pawn moves from g2 to g3. Recorded reply: **40...Qxf3**.

41.Rxf3 The rook captures the queen on f3. Recorded reply: **41...Rxf3**.

42.Qg6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **42...Kh8**.

43.Qxh6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From h6 it attacks king on h8 and rook on f8.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 20 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from +0 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on g7. Geometrically undefended: bishop on d7. Check for tactical protection.